

MEDIEVAL KNIGHTS AND BOWMEN

THE BATTLE OF CRÉCY

During the Hundred Years' War – the series of conflicts fought between the kings of France and England from 1337 to 1453 – the medieval knight's dominance of the European battlefield began to wane. At Crécy in 1346, mounted armoured warriors were shot down by common bowmen.

In medieval Europe, knights and men-at-arms were a social and military elite, traditionally accorded pride of place on the battlefield. Battles were supposed to be won by thundering charges in which nobles showed their prowess at fighting on horseback. In the course of wars with the Scots in the early 14th century, however, the English had learned the effectiveness of a different set of tactics. With knights and men-at-arms deployed on foot in a primarily defensive role, they used massed archers equipped with fast-shooting longbows to wreak havoc.

LONGBOW IN THE ASCENDANT

In 1346, King Edward III of England landed in France with some 7,000 longbowmen, about 4,000 mounted knights and men-at-arms, and several thousand assorted foot soldiers. Edward also brought with him a few small cannon, some of the earliest gunpowder weapons to be used in Europe. The king of France, Philip VI, was able to field a much larger army – his knights and men-at-arms alone probably numbered 12,000. He intercepted Edward south of Calais, forcing him to give battle. The English king drew up his forces in a defensive position on a ridge between Crécy and Wadicourt, dividing his dismounted knights and men-at-arms into three divisions, or "battles".

The encounter opened with a duel between Philip's archers (Genoese mercenaries armed with crossbows) and Edward's longbowmen. The Genoese advanced and shot their crossbow bolts to little effect. As they stopped to reload – a lengthy process – the longbows responded. According

to chronicler Jean Froissart: "The English archers advanced one step forward, and shot their arrows with such force and quickness, that it seemed as if it snowed."

Overwhelmed by the mass of arrows, the Genoese fell back. But discipline on the French side was poor. Their high-spirited noblemen considered themselves the finest knights in Europe, and they were more concerned with seeking personal glory than obeying their king's commands. Not waiting for orders, they began a piecemeal charge through the ranks of the fleeing Genoese. As the knights lumbered uphill, the longbow arrows brought down horses and men, reducing the charge to floundering chaos. The firing of the handful of cannon was barely noticed amid the devastation wrought by thousands of bowmen, each shooting at least five arrows a minute. Edward's infantry, armed with spears and knives, rushed forward to finish off the unhorsed Frenchmen.

The English did not enjoy an easy victory. The fighting continued beyond nightfall, the rival knights wielding their swords, maces, and war hammers in close combat. Froissart describes the French noblemen gathering their surviving followers around their individual banners to stage a gallant defence against the advancing enemy. Eventually King Philip fled the field, where more than a thousand of his knights lay dead. The superiority of massed longbows over armoured knights was to be witnessed again at Poitiers in 1356 and Agincourt in 1415 – without, however, lessening the prestige or status of the mounted elite.

